

Building your spike

How to turn a handful of scattered interests into the one thing that makes your application memorable.

The two philosophies

Well rounded

Being solidly involved in a bit of everything. Some sport, some clubs, some volunteering, spread fairly evenly. It looks tidy on paper, but on an application read in a few minutes alongside thousands of others, it rarely gives an admissions officer a reason to remember you.

A spike

One clear, standout strength or interest that you have pushed further than almost anyone else your age. Instead of being decent at ten different things, you become genuinely known for one, and everything else in your application supports it.

The one line version

Well rounded describes what you did. A spike describes who you are. Admissions officers remember people, not activity lists.

Why this matters more than it sounds like it should

An admissions officer reading your file has seen thousands of students who joined a lot of clubs and held a title in most of them. That story blends together fast. A student who spent two years building one real thing, a research project, a small business, a body of creative work, a community initiative, stands out simply because there is a specific story to tell about them, instead of a list to skim.

Two separate things, a spike and just staying busy

This is the part almost nobody explains clearly. Holding a long list of club memberships is not the same as having a spike. A real spike usually has three things going on together, sustained time invested in one direction, visible progress or output that someone outside your friend group can see, and a clear reason you personally care about it. Padding a list with titles you barely spent time on does not create any of those three.

A useful test

If you removed every other activity from your list and only kept your strongest one, would there still be a clear, specific story to tell about you? If yes, that is very likely your spike.

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A few common categories and what a real spike looks like inside each one

Category	What it can look like
Research	An independent project or a mentored study on one specific question, carried through
Creative	A consistent body of writing, art, music, or film that shows sustained interest and growth, rather than a single one-off piece.
Entrepreneurial	A small business, product, or service you actually built and ran, even at a small scale
Community	A specific initiative you started or led, with a measurable outcome, not just attendance
Technical	A tool, app, or dataset you built and kept improving over time

None of these require an expensive program or a fancy title to be real. What makes any of them a genuine spike is the time and thought behind it, not the price tag attached to it.

Important nuance

You do not need a paid summer program abroad to build a real spike. A well documented independent project done from home, with a clear question, a real process, and an honest result, reads just as strongly as an expensive one, sometimes more so.

How admissions officers actually evaluate a spike, in one paragraph

They are mainly looking for depth over time, a clear reason you cared, and some kind of visible output or progress, whether that is a paper, a product, a portfolio, or a result you can point to. They are not counting how many activities are on your list. A shorter list with one strong, well explained spike almost always reads stronger than a long list of shallow involvement.

Quick myths vs reality

Myth: Having a spike means you should drop every other activity.

Reality: Keep a few other meaningful activities. Your spike should be the clear centre of gravity, while everything else supports and strengthens it.

Myth: A spike has to involve winning a national award.

Reality: Recognition helps, but it is not required. A clearly documented process and honest result matter more than a trophy.

Myth: You need to know your spike before you can start building one.

Reality: Most spikes start as ordinary curiosity that someone kept pulling on for a year or two. You find it by starting, not by planning it out perfectly first.

Building your profile with this in mind

- Look at your current activities and ask which one you would keep even if nobody was grading you on it.
- Give that one activity the next six months of your spare time, instead of splitting it evenly across five.
- Create some kind of visible output along the way, a write up, a portfolio, a working prototype, so there is something concrete to show.
- Let your essays and recommendation letters reinforce the same story, instead of introducing a completely different one.

Every applicant's path to a spike looks different, and what reads as impressive can vary by school and by field. Use this as a starting framework, not a rigid formula.

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